

Bow tie pasta with roasted asparagus, oven-dried tomatoes, and crisp sage leaves in vegetable broth

This is a magnificent gourmet pasta dish, perfect for spring and summer, when fresh asparagus is at its peak. It's inundated with bold flavors, wonderful colors, and interesting textures. Homemade oven-dried tomatoes, grilled asparagus, and lemon juice are its key components. Fried sage leaves complete the dish; as they melt in your mouth, they provide a very special treat.

Essentially, this dish is about prepping, then assembling. You will use several techniques from the bold vegetarian chef's repertoire, but I promise, it is well worth the effort. That said, however, here are two shortcuts: To save time, use store-bought organic vegetable broth instead of home-made stock, and use store-bought sun-dried tomatoes, softened in hot water, instead of oven-dried.

1 bunch of fresh sage

2 cups Basic Vegetable Stock (page 45)
[500ml]

10 asparagus spears, tough ends removed

¼ cup plus 1 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil
[60ml]

4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

1 large carrot, thinly slivered

1 teaspoon crushed hot red pepper, or less
to taste

1 pound bow tie pasta

8 oven-dried plum tomatoes (see page 10)

Salt and freshly ground black pepper

¼ to ⅓ cup fresh lemon juice [60 to 75ml]

1. **Drop** several stems of sage leaves into a saucepan with the vegetable stock. Bring to a simmer, cover, remove from the heat, and let steep while preparing the rest of the dish.
2. Preheat the oven to 400°F [200°C]. Lightly **coat** the asparagus with 1 teaspoon of the olive oil. Place on a small baking sheet and roast for 8 to 10 minutes, or until lightly browned, not blackened.
3. Remove 16 of the remaining sage leaves from their stems, choosing the largest, without blemishes. In a medium skillet, **heat** the remaining ¼ cup olive oil over medium heat. Add the sage leaves and fry until just crisp and lightly browned, 1 to 2 minutes. Remove with a slotted spoon. Set aside on paper towels.
4. Reduce the heat to medium-low. **Add** the garlic, carrot, and hot pepper. Cook until the garlic is golden and the carrots have softened slightly. Set aside.
5. Bring to vigorous boil at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water. Add the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. **Cook** until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain quickly into a colander. Shake out the water completely.
6. Divide the cooked pasta, carrot-garlic-oil mixture, and tomatoes among 4 pasta bowls. **Top** with the asparagus spears.
7. Remove the sage leaves from the saucepan and ladle ¼ to ½ cup [60 to 125ml] of the stock into each bowl. **Season** generously with salt and black pepper and pour 1 to 1½ tablespoons of the lemon juice into each bowl. Lightly toss the ingredients, top with the crisp sage leaves, and serve immediately.

SERVES 4